

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Critical Arts

South-North Cultural and Media Studies

ISSN: 0256-0046 (Print) 1992-6049 (Online) Journal homepage: https://www.tandfonline.com/loi/rcrc20

New Trend, but Old Story: A Corpus-Assisted Discourse Study of Tibet Imaginations in Anglo-American Newspapers

Ming Liu

To cite this article: Ming Liu (2019) New Trend, but Old Story: A Corpus-Assisted Discourse Study of Tibet Imaginations in Anglo-American Newspapers, Critical Arts, 33:1, 1-14, DOI: 10.1080/02560046.2019.1583678

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/02560046.2019.1583678

Published online: 16 Apr 2019.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 136

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=rcrc20

CRITICAL ARTS
2019, VOL. 33, NO. 1, 1–14
https://doi.org/10.1080/02560046.2019.1583678

Check for updates

New Trend, but Old Story: A Corpus-Assisted Discourse Study of Tibet Imaginations in Anglo-American Newspapers

Ming Liu

School of International Studies, Sun Yat-sen University, Zhuhai, China; School of Foreign Languages, Shanghai Jiao Tong University, Shanghai, China

ABSTRACT

This paper provides a corpus-assisted discourse study of the representations of Tibet in five influential Anglo-American newspapers from 2000 to 2015. The findings suggest that while representations of Tibet revolved predominantly around political, religious and cultural discourses, they have become increasingly politicized since 2008. Driven by both politics and myths, Tibet was either constructed as a land under the "totalitarian rule" of the Chinese government or "objects of gaze" with its mythical and exotic religious practices and cultural arts. This was further reinforced by the negative representations of the Chinese Communist Party as "totalitarian", "repressive" and "atheist" and the positive representations of the Dalai Lama as a "spiritual leader" and "peace lover".

KEYWORDS

Tibet; corpus-assisted discourse study; critical discourse analysis; news; corpus linguistics

Introduction

As a remote and sparsely populated land in the western part of China, Tibet has long been the object of Western imaginations (Lopez 1998). Even before its first exposure to Europeans in the seventeenth century, myths had been generated about the "gold-digging ants and amazon nations in the highland of Inner Asia" (Dodin and Räther 2001b, xi). Interest was sustained even with the ensuing explorations and expeditions of European missionaries, explorers and travelers. Even today, Tibet still receives "far more attention in the Western world than one would expect for what remains one of the most remote parts of the world" (Crowe 2014, 1100).

Discourse plays a crucial role in the production and reproduction of Tibet imaginations in the Western world, and a number of studies have been conducted on the representations of Tibet in different types of discourses (Anand 2007a, 2007b; Bishop 1989; Dodin and Räther 2001b; Lopez 1998; Neuhaus 2012). It has now been acknowledged that discourses about a foreign land are far from accurate descriptions, but rather, socially and culturally constructed (Neuhaus 2012). Discursive constructions of a foreign land not only contribute to the images of the "Other" but also shed light on the constructions of "Self" because the representations of the Other must go "hand in hand with the construction, articulation, and affirmation of differences between the Self and Other"(Anand 2007b, 25).

CONTACT Liu Ming liumingford@gmail.com
© Critical Arts 2019
Critical Arts is co-published by Unisa Press and Informa Limited (trading as Taylor & Francis Group)

The representations of Tibet in dominant Western news media have thus drawn growing attention in recent years. The representations tend to vary with different historical periods due to different socio-political backgrounds (He 2010; Huang 2016). This is well illustrated by He's (2010) framing analysis of British media's representations of Tibet of four key events during the last 200 years: during the British invasion of Tibet (1903–1904), Tibet was portrayed in British media as a backward region in order to justify the British invasion of Tibet as a "liberation"; recently Tibet has been represented as a land of purity and exoticism which should not be destroyed by Chinese military forces. A diachronic investigation of the representations of the "Tibet question" in the *New York Times* (NYT) from 1980 to 2010 demonstrates changing interest in Tibet—its having once been intense in the 1990s, but then declining in the twenty-first century with the issues covered tending to be more diversified (Huang 2016).

However, no follow-up studies have been conducted to testify whether this trend continues in the twenty-first century. Previous studies mostly used framing analysis as their main analytic approach and failed to give a proper analysis of the discursive strategies involved. This paper fills in the gap by providing a corpus-assisted discourse study (CADS) of the representations of Tibet in dominant Anglo-American media at the beginning of this century (2000–2015) (Partington 2004). The primary purpose is to identify the general trends as well as the discursive strategies employed in the representations of Tibet during this period and to gain insights into the ideologies and socio-political factors behind their ways of representation.

Tibet in western imaginations: myth, history and politics

Previous studies have demonstrated three factors key to the representations of Tibet in the Western context: myth, history and politics (Dodin and Räther 2001a). The myth about Tibet had been generated in the West even before Tibet was named, but it was first given a coherent form in Hilton's (1933) novel *Lost Horizon*, in which he depicts a place in inner Asia called "Shangri-La", a place of eternal peace and serenity, in which the inhabitants practiced Buddhism (Neilson 2000). The mythical representation of Tibet as Shangri-La was further popularized by Frank Capra's 1937 film with the same title, and its influence can still be felt today because the theme of an Asian paradise still persists in Western media (Neilson 2000). The Shangri-La myth about Tibet serves as a cause for Tibetan separatists by emphasizing the unique identity of Tibet and providing a positive, moral weapon for the Western governments to accuse the Chinese government of destroying such a paradise (McKay 2001).

Competing with the mythical representations of Tibet are the historical representations of Tibet (He 2010; McKay 2001). Unlike the relatively stable mythical representations, the historical representations of Tibet tend to vary with different stages (McKay 2001). Western representations of Tibet tended to be negative in the beginning (Kaschewsky 2001). Alongside the belief of Western superiority, Tibetan Buddhism was represented as irrational and superstitious with native Tibetans as ugly. However, Western superiority over Tibet gradually gave way to much self-doubt in representations of Tibet because it had become a place where Westerners could find what they had supposedly lost in the two World Wars (McKay 2001). This trend continued from the liberation of Tibet to the Dalai Lama's flight to India in 1959, because Tibet's relative innocence and unspoiled

nature provided an ideal model for the war-torn and over-populated Europe. The historical representations of Tibet, therefore, vary with socio-political conditions in the West rather than Tibet itself (Dodin and Räther 2001a).

However, with the flight of the fourteenth Dalai Lama and his followers to India in 1959, politics has become another key factor in Tibet imaginations (Neuhaus 2012, xi), and the "Tibet question" arose (Crowe 2014; Shen 2015). Such an issue centers around Tibet's political status in regards to China but has no concern with providing evidence to win the argument (Shen 2015). For the Dalai Lama, the "Tibet question" is concerned with "genuine autonomy" for ethnic Tibetans within China; for the Chinese government, Tibet has become a "question" only because of the Dalai Lama, since Tibet has long been an integral part of China. While Western governments officially acknowledge Tibet as an integral part of China, they are inclined to take advantage of the "Tibet question" to push the Chinese government to meet their own political purposes. The political representations of Tibet can be better viewed as "the collective imagining by a large number of people of a description of their identity and their relations" (Barnett 2001, 271), and they are persuasive only to those who share that imagining. Tibet was thus represented in the West as a virgin land before the arrival of the People's Liberation Army (PLA), and the Western invasion of Tibet has been eliminated from Western political texts about Tibet since the 1980s.

Corpus-assisted discourse studies

The present study combines corpus linguistics (CL) and critical discourse analysis (CDA) by adopting the corpus-assisted discourse study (CADS) approach (Partington 2004). Viewing discourse as a social practice, CDA focuses on the role of discourse in the production and reproduction of power abuse or domination, and aims to expose "the opaque as well as transparent structural relationships of dominance, discrimination, power and control as manifested in the language" (Wodak 2001, 2). Taking a critical stance, the present study situates Anglo-American newspapers' representations of Tibet in the Western context and examines how they produce and reproduce the dominant discourses of contemporary Tibet imaginations. While the practice of using CL methods in CDA has become increasingly popular in the last decade, the CADS approach is characterized by an emphasis on the "synergy" of CL and CDA in their analysis, i.e. the balanced combination of the methods associated with CDA and CL (Baker et al. 2008). It has been applied to the study of media discourse on different topics, such as the Iraq War (Haarman and Lombardo 2009; Morley and Bayley 2009), immigrants and asylum seekers (Baker et al. 2008), Muslims (Baker, Gabrielatos, and McEnery 2013), climate change (Bevitori 2010), air pollution (Liu and Li 2017; Liu and Zhang 2018) and tourism discourse (Jaworska 2016).

This study presents a top-down analysis of the representations of Tibet by combining the methods associated with CL and the discourse-historical approach (DHA) (Reisigl and Wodak 2016). DHA emphasizes not only close textual analysis but also the integration of a large quantity of background information for a contextual understanding of texts. Texts can be analyzed at three different levels: (1) topics/themes, (2) discursive strategies and (3) linguistic realizations. The analysis typically starts from the identification of the content or topic(s) of a specific discourse to the investigation of discourse strategies as well as their linguistic realizations. While CL can help identify general patterns of data in

terms of frequencies, keywords, collocations, and their diachronic development, DHA provides the theoretical underpinnings for the close textual analysis and uncover the manipulative character of discursive practices (Baker et al. 2008).

Data collection and analytic methods

Data collection and corpus building

The study focuses on five influential English newspapers in the US and Britain: *The New York Times* (NYT) and *The Washington Post* (WP) from the US, *The Times* (TT), *The Guardian* (TG) and *The Daily Telegraph* (TDT) from Britain. Arising out of the same Anglo-American media system (Hallin and Mancini 2004), the five periodicals are known for their wide circulation in their respective countries and their agenda-setting influences in international news reporting (Cole 2010). All news texts with the keyword *Tibet* in the five newspapers from 2000 to 2015 were extracted by year from the electronic database Lexis-Nexis. All five newspapers provided extensive coverage of Tibet during the examined period, with the NYT (1995) taking the lead, followed by TG (1233), WP (1077), TT (1067), and TDT (694). They were first built into 16 yearly sub-corpora (after excluding information such as copyright, load date and byline from the news texts) and then combined as the corpus of Tibet news.

The five newspapers show similar trends in the number of articles collected over the 16 years (Figure 1). Despite sharp differences in 2000, the number of news articles collected in the following six years normalized in the five newspapers, with a total number of approximately 200 news articles for each newspaper. The number spiked to more than 1100 in 2008, which can be attributed to the riots in Lhasa and China's hosting of the 2008 Beijing Olympic Games. However, the following years saw a dramatic decline in the number of news articles collected, with an average number of about 400 in the following eight years. Overall, while Anglo-American newspapers' interest in Tibet seemed to decline after 2000 (Huang 2016), it rose again after 2008 with the number of new articles doubling in the latter period.

Analytic methods

This study began with the identification of keywords in each sub-corpus. Keywords refer to words which are statistically more frequently used in a subject corpus when compared with

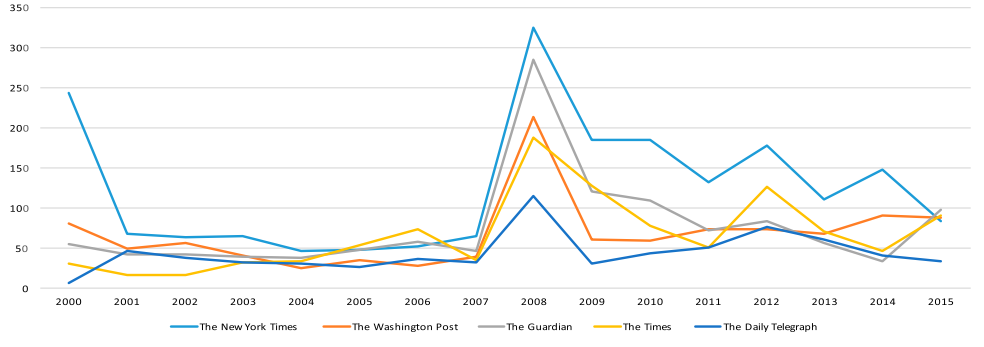


Figure 1. The overall distribution of new articles in each newspaper.

their uses in a general or specialized reference corpus, and they can suggest the "aboutness" of a subject corpus (Baker et al. 2008). With the corpus-analytic tool Wordsmith 5.0, each sub-corpus was first compared with a general reference corpus, the British National Corpus (BNC) 5 million sampler corpus, and a keyword list for each sub-corpus was produced. The keyword list ranked these keywords by their keyness values. The higher keyness values indicated keywords' higher statistical significance. The top 200 keywords in each list were further examined and classified into different semantic fields in order to identify the topics related to Tibet. The number of keywords in each semantic field suggests the saliency of these topics. A diachronic analysis of these semantic fields can expose the general trends in their preferential ways of representing these topics.

Some keywords in the dominant semantic fields were also further examined in their specific contexts to demonstrate the ways of constructing certain themes. The discursive strategies (i.e. nomination, predication, perspectivization, argumentation and intensification/mitigation) (Reisigl and Wodak 2016) were exposed through the analysis of collocates, concordance and co-texts. Collocates refer to words that co-occur with the node word (i.e. the word under investigation), typically within five words on either side of the node word. A concordance refers to "a list of all of the occurrences of a particular search term in a corpus, presented within the context that they occur in, usually a few words to the left and right of the search term" (Baker 2006, 71). However, further contexts of the search term were also examined when necessary in order to determine their specific contexts. Therefore, the analytic procedure is informed mutually by the theories and analytic methods of CL and CDA.

Analysis of semantic fields

The Wordsmith 5.0 application generated 16 keyword lists. An examination of the top 200 keywords in each list reveals the presence of seven semantic fields crucial to the constructions of Tibet: (1) Politics, (2) Religion, (3) Culture, (4) Ecology, (5) Sports, (6) Economics, and (7) Tourism. The keywords in each semantic field are illustrated as follows:

- **Politics**: *exile, official, protest, leader, communist, Han, president, Hu, Human, rights, visit, ethnic, Obama, peace, immolated, military, died, free, activist, Bush, crackdown, fled, government, independence, police, riot, Xi, Cameron, death, defence, detained, flag, Hillary, Jinping, Jintao, killed, Mao, security, arrest, Blair, Clinton, embassy, freedom, Jiang, Nobel, rule, unrest, uprising, arms, authorities, boycott, ceremony, congress, demonstrations, Hu's, Modi, paramilitary, peaceful, prison, pro, refugees, Tiananmen, troops, violence, war, Zemin, abuses, accusations, administration, advocacy, ambassador, anniversary, anti, Asylum, award, banners, Capitol, congressional, constitution, demonstrations, Deng, dialogue, dynasty, emperor, envoys, fire, flames, forces, gold, honour, King, legendary, medal, Merkel, Minister, Minstrels, Monarchy, patrol, political, postwar, Prime, propaganda, released, rescue, separatist, shot, soldiers, strikers, violent, Wen*
- **Religion**: *Buddhist, Dalai, Lama, spiritual, Lama's, monastery, monks, religious, Buddhism, monasteries, monk, religion, temple, Buddha, Panchen, Buddhists, Rinpoche, Lamas, meditation, reincarnation, holiness, nuns, prayer, pilgrims, Falun, Gong, sacred, temples, Buddha's, enlightenment, faith, nun, shrine, deities, nunnery, devotional, goddess,*

handprints, holy, Karma, Lord, Mandala, Muslim, Palace, pilgrimage, profanity, reincarnate, reincarnated, religions, succession, Sufi

- **Culture**: *artist, museum, painting, sculpture, art, cultural, gallery, theatre, arts, portrait, drawing, show, collection, exhibition, works, music, dance, festival, galleries, Jazz, armor, Broadway, film, folk, movie, Shangri-La, songs, band, concert, documentary, ensemble, metamuseum, painter, pianist, solo, story, tickets, comedy, craft, dancers, design, jewellery, musical, prints, silk, SPA, studio, album, architectural, artefacts, Ballet, bards, bronze, burial, caves, ceramics, Chamber, coloured, displays, epics, exhibit, exhibits, fashion, funeral, gold, guitarist, guitars, harp, herbal, leather, lute, masterpieces, opera, orchestra, painted, performances, performing, photos, piano, pictures, recital, relics, robes, saxophonist, silver, singing, storytellers, symphony, vase, watercolours, weaving, wooden*
- **Ecology**: *global, warming, panda, snow, earthquake, tiger, climate, dam, dams, glaciers, ice, pandas, quake, wild, antelope, engendered, glacier, gorges, grasslands, melting, remote, tigers*
- **Tourism**: *trip, tourists, camp, climbers, climb, expeditions, tour, travelling, trek, climber, journey, mountaineering, route, travel, travelled, travellers, adventure, expedition, climbed, climbing, mountaineers, tent, tents, tourism, travels, trekking*
- **Sports**: *Olympic*, *Olympics, Games, IOC, torch, Athletes, flame, relay*
- **Economics**: *railway*, *train*

The semantic field of politics consists of words referring to not only political leaders (e.g. *Obama*, *Bush*, *Xi*, *Hu*) and institutions (e.g. *parliamentary*, *congressional*), but also political conflicts, such as *protest*, *riot*, *fled*, and *killed*. They construct Tibet as a place of turmoil and conflicts. The semantic field of religion consists of keywords related primarily to Buddhism, such as *Buddhist*, *monastery*, and *religions*. They help construct Tibet as a place of Buddhism. The semantic field of culture consists of keywords related to Tibetan culture and arts (e.g. *art, artefacts, masterpieces*) as well as their exhibitions and performances, such as *performances*, *museum*, *show,* and *exhibition*. They help to construct Tibetan culture and arts as "objects of gaze" (Anand 2007b). The semantic field of ecology consists of keywords related to ecology and environment, such as *global*, *warming*, *grassland* and *tigers*. They help construct Tibet as a place of endangered environment and ecology. The semantic field of tourism consists of keywords related to travel and tourism, such as *trip*, *tourists*, *mountaineering* and *trekking*. They help to construct Tibet as a destination of tourism and adventure. The semantic field of sports consists of keywords related to Olympic Games, such as *Olympic*, *Games*, *torch* and *relay*. They appear as prominent keywords due to the 2008 Beijing Olympics serving as an opportunity for exiled Tibetans to try advancing their claims. The two keywords *railway* and *train* are roughly allocated to the semantic field of economics because they refer to the building of the Qinghai–Tibet railway, a strategic measure taken by the Chinese government for the economic development of Tibet.

Table 1 shows the exact numbers of these keywords in the seven semantic fields in each year. The semantic field of politics ranks first (431), followed respectively by the semantic fields of culture (344), religion (322), tourism (63), ecology (47), sports (20), and economy (3). They suggest that these newspapers still prefer to represent Tibet predominantly in terms of politics, culture and religion. Although the topics of tourism and ecology are also mentioned, they still do not emerge as dominant topics. As regarding the great

Table 1. The number of keywords in the seven semantic fields.

Types	2000	2001	2002	2003	2004	2005	2006	2007	2008	2009	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015
Politics	15	25	25	23	14	15	13	22	52	41	12	18	56	27	28	43
Religion	23	28	28	28	29	23	18	26	13	11	9	16	18	16	11	25
Culture	38	10	25	15	9	21	33	12	21	27	37	35	2	24	31	5
Ecology	0	2	0	3	6	9	7	3	1	1	3	0	4	2	3	3
Sports	0	4	0	0	1	0	0	4	7	0	0	0	0	0	0	4
Economics	0	0	0	0	0	0	2	1	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Tourism	0	7	0	10	10	4	4	12	1	1	1	1	3	5	3	1
Total	76	76	79	79	69	72	77	80	95	81	62	70	83	74	76	81

economic development in Tibet in this new century, even though the opening of the Qinghai–Tibet railway was covered in these newspapers, its representation primarily came across negatively, in terms of either economic exploitation or "cultural genocide", as in the following:

> (1) This railway across the roof of the world will result in an expanded Chinese military presence in Tibet, accelerate the already devastating exploitation of its natural resources and increase the number of Chinese migrants, marginalizing the Tibetan people still further.

It suggests that the representations of Tibet in dominant Anglo-American media still focus on the myth and politics (Dodin and Räther 2001b) rather than the economic development in Tibet. The representations of Tibet in terms of politics still underline Tibet as a place under the "totalitarian" control of the Chinese communist government (Shen 2015), as seen from keywords such as *protest*, *crackdown*, *arrest*, *shot*, and *killed*. The representations of Tibet in terms of religion and culture are actually consistent with the mythical or "exoticized" representations of Tibet (Anand 2007b). The representations of Tibet as a place of Buddhism and exotic religious practices (e.g. *meditation*, *reincarnation*), and the emphasis on the exhibitions and performances of Tibetan culture serve to construct Tibet as "objects of gaze" (Anand 2007b). To gaze does not just suggest curiosity but implies the superiority of the gazer over the object of the gaze.

The findings can be further confirmed by a diachronic analysis of the keywords in the seven semantic fields over the 16 years (see Figure 2). The three dominant topics (i.e. politics, religion and culture) can be identified in every year. Additionally, the topics of tourism and ecology are also relatively stable topics, being identified in most of the 16 years with occasional absences. However, sports and economy are occasional topics identified in some years. The topic of sports only occurred in the years when the Olympic Games became an important issue. The topic of economics only occurred in the two years during the Qinghai–Tibet railway's opening. This is consistent with the representations of Tibet in Western political texts, i.e. Tibet as a site of cultural, religious or environmental specialness (Barnett 2001, 275).

Nevertheless, different trends can be identified for the three dominant topics during the period. Overall, the religious topic tends to be relatively stable, even though a slight decline can be identified between 2004 and 2014. It suggests that the religious topic constitutes a relatively stable topic in these newspapers' representations of Tibet. Political and cultural topics show turbulent changes over the 16 years. There are three spikes in the topic of politics, which occurred respectively in 2008, 2012, and 2015. 2008 was the

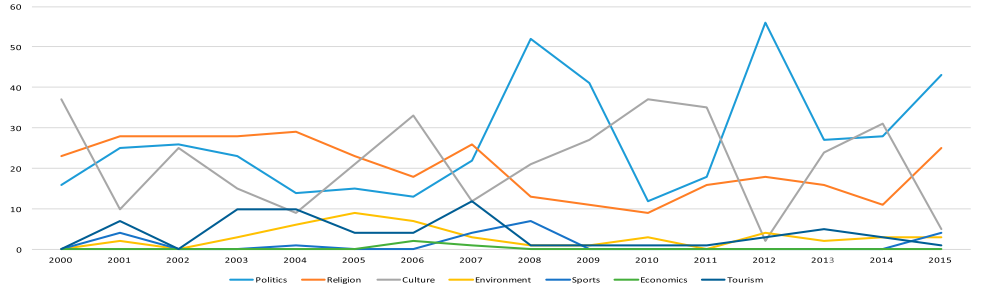


Figure 2. The distribution of the 7 semantic fields over 16 years.

year of Beijing Olympic Games and the breakout of the Tibetan riots in Lhasa. 2012 was the year when the former Chinese President visited India, a host place for exiled Tibetans, and a series of self-immolations occurred.

2015 was the year of the fiftieth anniversary of the founding of the Tibetan Autonomous Region. It suggests that the topic of politics is subject to the influences of dramatic events. The trend in the cultural topic runs in opposition to the trends of political and religious topics. When political and religious topics are on the rise, the cultural topic tends to decline. The cultural topic dominates only in the years when political and religious topics are less frequently mentioned, such as 2000, 2006, 2010, and 2014. In addition, these newspapers preferred to focus on the religious over the political before 2008, but the trend reversed after 2008. It suggests that the representations of Tibet in these newspapers have become increasingly politicized since 2008. To sum up, while representations of Tibet in terms of religion have been relatively stable over the 16 years, political representations are certainly on the rise, as they are subject to the influences of important political events, and the cultural representations dominate only in years when no important political representations can be identified.

Analysis of representative keywords

This section focuses on the analysis of two representative keywords in the topics of politics and religion: *communist* and *Dalai Lama*. Occurring as top keywords in almost every year, they are considered critical to the construction of Tibet in these newspapers, because they represent two key parties in the "Tibet question" (Crowe 2014).

Communist

The prominence of the word *communist* indicates the presence of anti-communist ideology in Anglo-American newspapers' representations of Tibet. According to Herman and Chomsky (1988, 2), anti-communism can be regarded as "a national religion and control mechanism" in Western media because the concept of communism has been considered as a threat to Western democracy and capitalism. Communists have often been constructed as "sinister, conspiring, terroristic, atheistic, power-hungry, monolithic, anti-human, and inhuman" (Parenti 1969, 44). The arousal of anti-communist fervor eliminates the necessity of serious evidence for the claims of "communist" abuses, and "charlatans can serve as evidential sources" (Herman and Chomsky 1988, 30).

The anti-communist ideology can be revealed by the nomination strategy employed by these newspapers, i.e. the ways of referring to social actors and phenomena (Reisigl and Wodak 2016). An examination of the collocates of *communist* (5798) at its R1 position (i.e. the first position to the right) reveals that it is followed by some nominal collocates, and their exact numbers of occurrences are illustrated as follows:

> *party* (3224), *party's* (371), *government* (187), *rule* (166), *China* (161), *regime* (106), *leader* (88), *leadership* (75), *rulers* (62), *leaders* (61), *Chinese* (59), *authorities* (56), *revolution* (48), *state* (46), *troops* (44), *youth* (35), *takeover* (34), *dictatorship* (33), *country* (25), *ideology* (24), *officials* (21)

As can be expected, *communist* is used primarily to label the communist party, which does not necessarily incur anti-communist ideology. However, the use of *communist* in front of some other nouns will carry apparent negative meanings, such as *rule*, *regime*, *rulers*,

takeover, and *dictatorship*. They contribute to the construction of Tibet as a place under the "occupation" and "totalitarian" control of the Chinese communist party. However, even the use of *communist* in front of these nouns with no apparent evaluative meanings also suggests the presence of anti-communist ideology, such as *government*, *China*, *leader*, *leadership*, *leaders*, *Chinese*, *authorities*, *revolution*, *state*, *troops*, *youth*, *country* and *officials*. It foregrounds communist as a key feature of China, the Chinese government, and its officials, and represents a typical case of "over-lexicalization", i.e. "an excess of quasi-synonymous terms for entities and ideas that are a particular preoccupation or problem in the culture's discourse" (Fowler 1991, 85). From the Western perspective, anything related to communist, no matter how good it is, will be ideologically wrong (Herman and Chomsky 1988).

The anti-communist ideology can also be revealed in the predication strategies of *communist*, i.e. the ways of qualifying social actors and phenomena (Reisigl and Wodak 2016). *Communist* is found modified by such adjective collocates at its L1 position (i.e. the first position to the left) as *atheist* (52), *totalitarian* (12), *hardline* (8), and *repressive* (5). They all carry negative meanings which contribute to constructing communists as "atheist", "totalitarian" and "repressive".

The anti-communist ideology can be further seen through the examination of the collocation of *communist* and *Tibet*. Two arguments dominate in their specific contexts of use. First, Tibet was invaded by the communist troops in the 1950s, as in the following:

> (2) It enjoyed de facto independence until the previous King asked the Government of Nepal for protection after ***Communist*** Chinese troops *occupied Tibet* in 1950.

The emphasis on the invasion of Tibet by the communist troops de-legitimizes the status of Tibet as an integral part of China and adds coherence to the negative constructions of the Chinese government and its policies in Tibet. This gives rise to the second argument that Tibet is under the repressive rule of the Chinese government, as in the following:

> (3) To enforce its rule over *Tibet*, the ***Communist*** Party has linked Lhasa to the rest of China with the world's highest railway and encouraged a wave of settlement.

> (4) Since *Tibet* was first incorporated into ***Communist*** China in 1951, the Roof of the World has rested uneasily on the Middle Kingdom.

As Yu (2010) suggests, the ideological divide between communism and anti-communism is crucial to understanding this situation. It is not the Chinese takeover of Tibet but the official *communist* takeover in Tibet that is really unacceptable to the West. The liberation of Tibet in the 1950s wiped out the last stronghold for the anti-communist system in Mainland China, thus becoming unacceptable to Westerners. Therefore, the labelling of China as "communist", whether accurate or not, is ideologically driven. It underlines Western imaginations about Tibet, and sustains much of Western hostility towards the Chinese, specially its government and policies (Yu 2010).

Dalai Lama

Another key theme is Dalai Lama because *Dalai* and *Lama*, as keywords, appear in all the 16 years. The most frequent collocates at the L1 position of *Dalai Lama* (27040) are *the* (23194), *exiled* (321), *14th* (313), *old* (176), *current* (157), *next* (127), *13th* (104), *of* (67), and *15th* (59). It

can be found that *Dalai Lama* is modified primarily by the definite article *the*, which refers solely to the current Dalai Lama, the fourteenth Dalai Lama. However, *Dalai Lama* is also modified by thirteenth, which refers to the thirteenth Dalai Lama. It is used to emphasize that the fourteenth Dalai Lama is the reincarnation of the thirteenth Dalai Lama. The fifteenth Dalai Lama is also mentioned, as can be witnessed in the collocate *15th* due to the discussion of the selection of the next Dalai Lama. The collocate *exiled* is also highlighted to emphasize the exiled state of the fourteenth Dalai Lama. *Old* also occurs as a frequent collocate before *Dalai Lama* to refer to the age of the Dalai Lama because these newspapers try to impress the readers with the old age of the Dalai Lama, which is consistent with the ideology of constructing the Dalai Lama as an old wise man ever since the Dalai Lama received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1989. It confirms Huang's (2016) finding that the Dalai Lama serves as a key actor in the representations of Tibet.

An examination of the most frequent lexical collocates of *Dalai Lama* reveals that several lexical collocates represent the predication strategies for the Dalai Lama, such as *leader* (2162), *holiness* (374), *separatist* (230), *Nobel* (194), *Tenzin* (175), *Gyatso* (145), *head* (116), and *clique* (103). It can be seen that *Dalai Lama* collocates overwhelmingly with the word *leader*. An examination of the collocation of *leader* at the five positions to the left and right of *Dalai Lama* reveals that Dalai Lama is labelled primarily as an exiled Tibetan spiritual leader (see Table 2).

The emphasis on the spiritual identity of the Dalai Lama is also reflected in the collocate *holiness* (374). The Dalai Lama is frequently referred to as *His Holiness*, as in the following:

> (5) In 2008, for example, ***His Holiness*** the *Dalai Lama* asked Tibetans to cease the hunger strikes they were staging in response to China's repressive policies.

Meanwhile, the Dalai Lama has also been frequently referred to as the Nobel peace prize winner, as can be witnessed in the collocate *Nobel* (194), as in the following:

> (6) The *Dalai Lama*, a winner of the ***Nobel*** Peace Prize and one of the world's most prominent advocates of nonviolence, said in an interview yesterday that …

Therefore, the Dalai Lama is constructed as a spiritual leader, "a quintessential figure for freedom and peace" (Yu 2010, 2).

Nevertheless, the Dalai Lama has also been constructed as a separatist, as can be witnessed in the collocate *separatist* (230). This nomination strategy, however, has been frequently attributed to China or the Chinese government, as in the following:

Table 2. Typical patterns of the collocation of *Dalai Lama* and *Leader*.

Rank	Dalai Lama and Leader	Freq.	Leader and Dalai Lama	Freq.
1	Dalai Lama, the exiled Tibetan spiritual leader	177	Tibetan spiritual leader, the Dalai Lama	116
2	Dalai Lama, the spiritual leader	142	Exiled spiritual leader, the Dalai Lama	72
3	Dalai Lama, the Tibetan spiritual leader	127	Tibetan spiritual leader the Dalai Lama	60
4	Dalai Lama, Tibet's spiritual leader	98	Tibet's spiritual leader, the Dalai Lama	49
5	Dalai Lama, the exiled spiritual leader	95	Their spiritual leader, the Dalai Lama	45
6	Dalai Lama, Tibet's exiled spiritual leader	61	Their exiled leader, the Dalai Lama	44
7	Dalai Lama, the exiled Tibetan leader	47	Exiled Tibetan leader, the Dalai Lama	30
8	Dalai Lama, spiritual leader	32	Its spiritual leader, the Dalai Lama	15
9	Dalai Lama, their spiritual leader	25	Buddhist spiritual leader, the Dalai Lama	12
10	Dalai Lama, the leader	19	Exiled religious leader, the Dalai Lama	9

Table 3. Analysis of verbal acts.

Types	*accused*	*denounce*	*accuses*	*blamed*	*claims*
Sayer	75	0	11	25	30
Target	226	171	139	106	118
Others	48	0	5	5	0
Total	349	171	155	136	148

(7) China regards the *Dalai Lama* as a dangerous ***separatist***.

(8) China blames what it calls the *Dalai Lama* ***clique*** for orchestrating the violence.

Therefore, the Anglo-American newspapers construct the Dalai Lama as an exiled, old and wise spiritual leader, who has been persecuted by the Chinese government. This typical way of constructing the Dalai Lama can also be revealed in the perspectivization strategy employed in the representations of speech acts, i.e. from what perspective these nominations, attributions and arguments are expressed (Reisigl and Wodak 2016). Among the verb collocates of *Dalai Lama*, some carry apparent evaluative meanings, such as *accused* (349), *denounce* (171), *accuses* (155), *claims* (148) and *blamed* (136). In order to examine the perspective, the concordance lines of these attitudinal verbs were further analysed to see whether the Dalai Lama is constructed as the sayer of these verbal acts or as the target of these verbal acts. The findings are illustrated in Table 3.

It can be found that the Dalai Lama is constructed more as the target of these verbal acts than as the sayer. These negative verbal acts contribute both to the construction of the Dalai Lama as a victim of accusations, denouncement, claims and blames and to the distance of these statements by the news reporters, as in the following:

(9) The leader of Tibet ***accused*** the Dalai Lama yesterday of disguising behind fine words his goal of independence for the Himalayan region.

Therefore, the Dalai Lama was constructed as a spiritual leader and a peace lover while also as a target of China's verbal attacks. Such representations help construct an "innocent" Dalai Lama under the attack of a "totalitarian" Chinese government.

Conclusion

A CADS study of Anglo-American newspaper representations of Tibet has revealed both new trends and old stories. While Tibet was represented in terms of several topics, the three topics of politics, culture and religion still predominate, constructing Tibet as either an oppressed land under the "totalitarian" control of the Chinese government or "objects of gaze" for its mythical and exotic religious practices as well as culture and arts. A diachronic analysis has also shown that the Western media's interest in Tibet, instead of declining (Huang 2016), has increased since 2008, and that the representations of Tibet have become increasingly politicized. Behind Western imaginations of Tibet still lies an anti-communist ideology, which can be detected through typical discursive strategies for representing communists. By contrast, the Dalai Lama was constructed primarily as a spiritual leader and a victim of the accusations and criticism of the Chinese government. Tibet was thus constructed as a place of "contrasts and superlatives": either as an oppressed land under the "totalitarian" control of the Chinese government or as the mysterious and holy land with the Dalai Lama as the spiritual leader (He 2010, 107).

Imagining Tibet in Anglo-American newspapers is still subject to the influences of two factors in this century: politics and myths. The mythical representations of Tibet can be found in the reduction of Tibet as "religious" and the Dalai Lama as a "spiritual leader" and "peace lover", while the political representations of Tibet can be identified in the construction of Tibet as a land under the "repressive rule" of the Chinese communist government with communists as "totalitarian", "repressive", and "atheist". However, the history of Tibet as a land subject to the intrusions of dominant Western countries has failed to be addressed in these representations. Behind the new trends still lies the old story of Tibet as "a happy, peaceful people devoted to the practice of Buddhism whose remote and ecologically enlightened land, ruled by a god king, was invaded by the force of evil" (Lopez 1998, 10). While the mythical representations of Tibet indicate the superiority of dominant Western countries, the political representations of Tibet underline the demand for their "paternal" love in Tibet. The representations of Tibet are "too closely related to ideologies, worldviews, and agendas that are not necessarily linked with Tibet itself" (Barnett 2001). Therefore, a CADS approach has demonstrated not only the specific images constructed for Tibet but also the particular discursive strategies employed for constructing Tibet. It is expected that the present study can contribute to the growing literature of using CL methods in CDA.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author.

Funding

The writing of this article was supported by the 'MOE (Ministry of Education in China) Project of Humanities and Social Sciences' (ID No.: 16YJC740046).

References

Anand, D. 2007a. *Geopolitical Exotica: Tibet in Western Imagination*. London: University of Minnesota Press.

Anand, D. 2007b. "Western Colonial Representations of the Other: The Case of Exotica Tibet." *New Political Science* 29 (1): 23–42.

Baker, P. 2006. *Using Corpora in Discourse Analysis*. London and New York: Continuum.

Baker, P., C. Gabrielatos, M. KhosraviNik, T. McEnery, and R. Wodak. 2008. "A Useful Methodological Synergy? Combining Critical Discourse Analysis and Corpus Linguistics to Examine Discourses of Refugees and Asylum Seekers in the UK Press." *Discourse and Society* 19 (3): 273–306.

Baker, P., C. Gabrielatos, and T. McEnery. 2013. "Sketching Muslims: A Corpus Driven Analysis of Representations Around the Word 'Muslim' in the British Press 1998–2009." *Applied Linguistics* 34 (3): 255–278.

Barnett, R. 2001. "'Violated Specialness': Western Political Representations of Tibet." In *Imagining Tibet: Perceptions, Projections, and Fantasies*, edited by T. Dodin, and H. Räther, 269–316. Boston: Wisdom Publications.

Bevitori, C. 2010. *Representations of Climate Change: News and Opinion Discourse in UK and US Quality Press*. Bologna: Bologna University Press.

Bishop, P. 1989. *The Myth of Shangri-La: Tibet, Travel Writing, and the Western Creation of Sacred Landscape*. Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press.

Cole, W. M. 2010. "No news is Good News: Human Rights Coverage in the American Print Media, 1980–2000." *Journal of Human Rights* 9 (3): 303–325.
Crowe, D. M. 2014. "The 'Tibet Question': Tibetan, Chinese and Western Perspectives." *Nationalities Papers* 41 (6): 1100–1135.
Dodin, T., and H. Räther. 2001a. "Imagining Tibet: Between Shangri-La and feudal Oppression." In *Imgaining Tibet: Perceptions, Projections, and Fantasies*, edited by T. Dodin, and H. Räther, 391–416. Boston: Wisdom Publications.
Dodin, T., and H. Räther. 2001b. *Imagining Tibet: Perceptions, Projections, and Fantasies*. Boston: Wisdom Publications.
Fowler, R. 1991. *Language in the News: Discourse and Ideology in the Press*. London: Routledge.
Haarman, L., and L. Lombardo, eds. 2009. *Evaluation and Stance in War News*. London: Continuum.
Hallin, D. C., and P. Mancini. 2004. *Comparing Media Systems: Three Models of Media and Politics*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
He, M. 2010. "An Analysis of Framing in British News Media Representations of China and the Chinese." (Unpublished Ph.D. thesis). Loughborough University.
Herman, E. S., and N. Chomsky. 1988. *Manufacturing Consent: The Political Economy of the Mass Media*. New York: Pantheon Books.
Hilton, J. 1933. *Lost Horizon*. London: MacMillan.
Huang, M. 2016. *The New York Times' s Coverage of Tibetan Issues and China's International Communication Strategies*. London: Global China Press.
Jaworska, S. 2016. "A comparative Corpus-Assisted Discourse Study of the Representations of Hosts in Promotional Tourism Discourse." *Corpora* 11 (1): 83–111.
Kaschewsky, R. 2001. "The image of Tibet in the West Before the Nineteenth Century." In *Imagining Tibet: Perceptions, Projections, and Fantasies*, edited by T. Dodin, and H. Räther, 1–20. Boston: Wisdom Publications.
Liu, M., and C. Li. 2017. "Competing Discursive Constructions of China's Smog in Chinese and Anglo-American English-Language Newspapers: A Corpus-Assisted Discourse Study." *Discourse and Communication* 11 (4): 386–403.
Liu, M., and Y. Zhang. 2018. "Discursive Constructions of Scientific (Un) Certainty About the Health Risks of China's Air pollution: A Corpus-Assisted Discourse Study." *Language and Communication* 60: 1–10.
Lopez, D. S. J. 1998. *Prisoners of Shangri-la: Tibetan Buddhism and the West*. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press.
McKay, A. C. 2001. "'Truth', Perception, and Politics: The British Construction of an Image of Tibet." In *Imagining Tibet: Perceptions, Projections, and Fantasies*, edited by T. Dodin, and H. Räther, 67–89. Boston: Wisdom Publications.
Morley, J., and P. Bayley, eds. 2009. *Corpus-Assisted Discourse Studies on the Iraq Conflict: Wording the War*. New York and London: Routledge.
Neilson, B. 2000. "Inside Shangri-la/Outside Globalisation: Remapping Orientalist Visions of Tibet." *Communal/Plural: Journal of Transnational & Cross-Cultural Studies* 8 (1): 95–112.
Neuhaus, T. 2012. *Tibet in the Western Imagination*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.
Parenti, M. 1969. *The Anti-communist Impulse*. New York: Random House.
Partington, A. 2004. "Corpora and Discourse, A Most Congruous Beast." In *Corpora and Discourse*, edited by A. Partington, J. Morley, and L. Haarman, 11–20. Bern: Peter Lang.
Reisigl, M., and R. Wodak. 2016. "The Discourse-Historical Approach." In *Methods of Critical Discourse Analysis*, edited by R. Wodak, and M. Meyer, 23–61. London: Sage.
Shen, W. 2015. "The Diffusion of EU Norms to China: The Case of Tibet." In *Importing EU Norms*, edited by A. Björkdahl, N. Chaban, J. Leslie, and A. Masselot, 231–246. New York: Springer.
Wodak, R. 2001. "What CDA is About—A Summary of Its History, Important Concepts and its Developments." In *Methods of Critical Discourse Analysis*, edited by R. Wodak, and M. Meyer, 1–13. London: Sage.
Yu, T. 2010. "Deconstructing the Master Narrative on Tibet: Lessons for Education." *Discourse: Studies in the Cultural Politics of Education* 31 (1): 1–15.